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Section Title(S)

THE GENERATIONAL METHOD • The Joking Relationship

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## THE GENERATIONAL METHOD

Before proceeding with a description of the application of kin terms by the generational method, a description of the joking relationship and some general principles with respect to the terms should be given.

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### *The Joking Relationship*

Every relationship in which kin terms are applied is one in which joking is either permitted or forbidden; every kin term carries its joking status (which will be given when the terms are set forth). The application of kin terms is so extensive that it comes to involve the whole population of the Nyae Nyae region, with the result that a !Kung, by the rules of the system, is specifically permitted or forbidden to joke with every other !Kung he knows.

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Joking is in the foreground of people's awareness. It came up constantly in our talks about kinship. The !Kung were apparently not always assiduous in teaching their children the exact biological position of their kinsmen (whether a given man was FaBr or MoBr, for instance), and a person would not always know *why* he applied a certain term to someone, but he would know that the term he used was proper, and he would know the proper joking status to observe; that would have been well taught him by his parents. The !Kung, I believe, take satisfaction—perhaps I should say they take security—in knowing

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proper behavior and conforming to it. This is true of their behavior in the joking relationship. It was disturbing to them not to have a clearly established joking status with the members of our expedition. This was one of the reasons for their quickly giving us !Kung names.<sup>3</sup> Through the names we took our place  205 in their scheme of things, and everyone knew whether or not he must refrain from joking with us.

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3. It was #Toma who bestowed names on our family. He gave me his mother's name, Di//khao, and I was called Di//khao N!a (Old Di//khao) by all. Laurence was named Tsamgao N!a for #Toma's father. Elizabeth was named Di!ai for !U's sister, I think at Di!ai's request. #Toma gave John his own name.

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